Topic 6 — Indian Dance

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Indian Classical Dances, Bharatanatyam, Kathak, Kathakali, Kuchipudi, Mohiniyattam, Odissi, Manipuri, Sattriya, Folk Dances, Tribal Dances

Sources: NCERT *An Introduction to Indian Art* (Class 11), Natyashastra, Sangeet Natak Akademi, UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage lists. **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs

- **Garba of Gujarat** entered the UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage list in **December 2023**. It is a folk form. It is not one of the eight classical dances.
- **Yamini Krishnamurthy**, a leading exponent of Bharatanatyam and Kuchipudi, died on **3 August 2024**.
- **Birju Maharaj** (बिरजू) of the Lucknow Kathak gharana died in **January 2022**.
- **Kalbelia** (कालबेलिया) of Rajasthan entered UNESCO ICH in **2010**.
- **Chhau** (छऊ) entered UNESCO ICH in **2010**. It is still not on the Sangeet Natak Akademi list of eight.
- **Sankirtana** (संकीर्तन) of Manipur entered UNESCO ICH in **2013**. It is ritual music and dance. It is not a ninth classical dance.
- The **Sangeet Natak Akademi** (संगीत नाटक अकादेमी) was founded in **1952**. That year is not the year Sattriya was added.

6.1 Indian Classical Dances

The root text is the **Natyashastra** of **Bharata Muni**. The Sangeet Natak Akademi list has **eight** classical dances. **Sattriya** became the eighth in **2000**.

- The **Sangeet Natak Akademi** recognises **eight** classical dances.
- A list of **seven** has dropped **Sattriya**.
- **Sattriya** of Assam was added to the Akademi list in **November 2000**. It is the latest of the eight.
- **Chhau** is not one of the eight. It is on the UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage list. Some ministry notes call it a ninth style. That is not the Akademi classical list.
- The root treatise is the **Natyashastra**, ascribed to **Bharata Muni**.
- The Natyashastra teaches **nine rasas**.

Terms used in every classical form

- **Nritta** is pure movement. It carries no story.
- **Nritya** is movement plus expression. Story comes through hasta (hand) and mukhaja (face).

- **Natya** is dance-drama. Kathakali and Kuchipudi lean this way.
- **Lasya** is graceful movement, linked with Parvati or Mohini.
- **Tandava** is vigorous movement, linked with Shiva.
- **Angika** abhinaya is expression through the body.
- **Vachika** abhinaya is expression through speech or song.
- **Aharya** abhinaya is costume and makeup. Kathakali lives here.
- **Sattvika** abhinaya is inner emotion made visible.

Rasa	Mood
Shringara	love
Hasya	humour
Karuna	compassion
Raudra	anger
Veera	valour
Bhayanaka	fear
Bibhatsa	disgust
Adbhuta	wonder
Shanta	peace (the later ninth)

- The *Abhinaya Darpana* of **Nandikesvara** is the companion text on hasta-mudras and bodily expression.
- Among the eight, **Bharatanatyam**, **Kuchipudi**, and **Mohiniyattam** use **Carnatic** (कर्नाटक) music.
- Among the eight, only **Kathak** uses **Hindustani** (हिंदुस्तानी) music.

The eight, by state

- **Bharatanatyam** belongs to **Tamil Nadu**.
- **Kathak** belongs to North India. Its main Uttar Pradesh centre is **Lucknow**. Jaipur is the Rajasthan gharana.
- **Kathakali** belongs to **Kerala**.
- **Kuchipudi** belongs to **Andhra Pradesh**. The name comes from the village of Kuchipudi in Krishna district.
- **Mohiniyattam** belongs to **Kerala**.
- **Odissi** belongs to **Odisha** (ओडिशा).
- **Manipuri** belongs to **Manipur**.
- **Sattriya** belongs to **Assam**. The Akademi recognised it in **2000**.

> **Logic:** Kerala has **two** classical forms, Kathakali and Mohiniyattam. Kathak is not Kathakali. Sattriya is the eighth and the latest.

6.2 Bharatanatyam

Tamil Nadu | temple sadir | Carnatic

- The core stance is **araimandi**, a half-sit with the knees turned out so the legs form a triangle.
- The geometry is often compared to a temple fire or to Nataraja's iconography.
- The Tanjore Quartet shaped the concert **margam**. A typical sequence runs alarippu, then varnam, then tillana.
- **Rukmini Devi Arundale** led the twentieth-century stage revival at **Kalakshetra**.
- **E. Krishna Iyer** worked to destigmatise sadir and bring it onto the public stage.
- The main banis (schools) are Pandanallur, Vazhuvoor, and Kalakshetra.
- **Yamini Krishnamurthy** danced Bharatanatyam and Kuchipudi. She died on **3 August 2024**.
- Bharatanatyam is not from Kerala. It is not Odissi tribhanga.

> **Logic:** Sadir became Bharatanatyam. Rukmini Devi is Kalakshetra. She is not a Kathak name.

6.3 Kathak

North India | Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh | Hindustani

- Kathak is the only form among the eight that uses the **Hindustani** musical system.
- The origin is the temple *kathaka*, a storyteller. The saying is *Katha kahe so kathak kahave*.
- Do not confuse **Kathak** the dance with **Kathaka**, a priestly reciter name linked in some texts with the Shukla Yajurveda.
- Technical markers are **tatkar** (rhythmic footwork), **chakkar** (rapid spins), and **ghungroo**.
- Mughal and Awadh courts turned temple katha into a court spectacle.
- The peak Awadh patron is Nawab **Wajid Ali Shah** (वाजिद अली शाह). He is not Akbar.

Three gharanas

- The **Lucknow** gharana is known for grace, abhinaya, and thumri. It belongs to **Uttar Pradesh**.
- Lucknow names to remember are **Kalka–Bindadin**, **Birju Maharaj**, and **Shambhu Maharaj**.
- The **Jaipur** gharana is known for strong footwork and a tandava colour. It belongs to Rajasthan.
- The **Banaras** gharana is linked to **Janakiprasad**. It uses floorwork and natwari. It belongs to **Uttar Pradesh**.
- **Birju Maharaj** died on **16 January 2022**. He belongs to the Lucknow line.
- Accompaniment uses tabla, pakhawaj, sarangi, and harmonium. The mridangam is a Carnatic drum and is not the Kathak marker.

> **Logic:** Lucknow Kathak belongs to **Uttar Pradesh**. Wajid Ali Shah is the Awadh peak.

6.4 Kathakali

Kerala | dance-drama | traditionally men

- Kathakali uses heavy **aharya**. The makeup is called **chutti**.
- **Pacha** (green) marks the noble hero or a divine figure.
- **Kathi** marks the arrogant or villainous royal.
- **Thadi** (beard) marks fierce or comic types.
- **Kari** marks a demoness or hunter.
- **Minukku** marks women or sages and looks radiant.
- Stories come from the Ramayana, the Mahabharata, and the Puranas. Plays can run all night.
- Music uses chenda, maddalam, and chengila. It is not Hindustani khayal.
- The training home is **Kerala Kalamandalam**, linked with **Vallathol Narayana Menon**.
- Kathakali is not Mohiniyattam. It is not north Indian Kathak.

> **Logic:** A green face marks the hero. Kathakali is Kerala male dance-drama.

6.5 Kuchipudi

Andhra Pradesh | village Kuchipudi (Krishna district) | dance-drama

- The founding saint-composer is **Siddhendra Yogi**.
- His masterwork is the dance-drama **Bhama Kalapam**, centred on Satyabhama.
- **Tarangam** is dancing on a **brass plate**, often with a pot on the head. That plate is the famous marker.
- The form began as Yakshagana-like village dance-drama and later became a solo concert form.
- **Yamini Krishnamurthy** is also remembered as a Kuchipudi exponent.
- Kuchipudi is not from Tamil Nadu. It is not the plate-less margam of Bharatanatyam.

> **Logic:** The plate is Kuchipudi tarangam. The village is in **Andhra Pradesh**, not Tamil Nadu.

6.6 Mohiniyattam

Kerala | female solo | lasya (Mohini)

- The dancer wears an off-white handloom saree with a gold border, the **kasavu** saree.
- The movement is a soft sway. It is not Kathakali's jumps and stamps.
- Revival is linked to **Vallathol Narayana Menon** and Kerala Kalamandalam. That is the same house as Kathakali, but a different form.
- Mohiniyattam is Kerala's second classical dance. Do not swap it with Kathakali.

> **Logic:** Kerala female, white-and-gold, is Mohiniyattam. Kerala male, green-face, is Kathakali.

6.7 Odissi

Odisha | Jagannath, Puri | tribhanga

- The other stance is **chowk**, a square masculine pose.
- One stream is **mahari**, temple women dancers.
- The other stream is **gotipua**, boys dressed as women. Concert nartaki comes later.
- The twentieth-century reconstruction is led by **Kelucharan Mohapatra**. Pankaj Charan Das and Deba Prasad Das also belong here.
- Sculpture on Odisha temples such as Konark and Jagannath matches Odissi poses.
- Odissi is not Bharatanatyam araimandi.

> **Logic:** Tribhanga is Odissi. Gotipua is not mahari.

6.8 Manipuri

Manipur | Vaishnava Ras | soft rounded movement

- The earliest ritual layer is **Lai Haraoba**, the merrymaking of the gods.
- The spiritual core of Manipuri classical dance is **Ras Lila**, the love of Radha, Krishna, and the gopis.
- **Pung Cholom** is the drum dance.
- **Kartal Cholom** is the cymbal dance.
- Ras costume is white or pale, with a barrel skirt.
- Guru **Bipin Singh** shaped the modern concert form.
- **Sankirtana** of Manipur, song plus drum plus dance, entered UNESCO in **2013**. Do not call Sankirtana a ninth SNA classical dance.
- Manipuri Ras Lila is not the **Braj Raslila** folk play of Uttar Pradesh.

> **Logic:** Manipuri Ras is classical Manipur. Braj Raslila is **Uttar Pradesh folk**.

6.9 Sattriya

Assam | Srimanta Sankaradeva | Akademi classical from 2000

- Sattriya was born in **satra** monasteries as Vaishnava preaching.
- It mixes music, dance, and drama. The play form is **Ankiya Nat** (अंकिया नाट) or **Bhaona** (भाओना).
- It is not only a festival item. It is also a daily satra ritual.

- Male monks performed originally. Women perform in the concert age.
- The instruments are **khol** and **taal**. The songs are **borgeet**.
- Sattriya is the latest of the eight. It is not Odissi. It is not Manipuri.

> **Logic:** Sattriya is Assam, Sankaradeva, and **2000**. Dropping it produces the false “seven classical dances.”

6.10 Folk Dances

Rule: These are community and festival dances. They are not on the Sangeet Natak Akademi list of eight.

- **Bhangra** belongs to Punjab. It is a Baisakhi harvest dance for males.
- **Giddha** (गिद्धा) belongs to Punjab. It is for women and uses boliyan.
- **Garba** belongs to Gujarat. It is a Navratri circle around a lamp or Amba. It is UNESCO **Dec 2023**.
- **Dandiya Raas** belongs to Gujarat. It uses sticks. It is not the same item as Garba.
- **Lavani** belongs to Maharashtra. It is a powerful female form linked to **Tamasha** (तमाशा) folk theatre.
- **Koli** belongs to the Maharashtra coast. It is a fisherfolk dance.
- **Ghoomar** (घूमर) belongs to Rajasthan. It uses a swirling ghagra.
- **Kalbelia** belongs to Rajasthan. It is a snake-community swirl. It is UNESCO **2010**.
- **Bihu** belongs to Assam. It is danced at Bohag Bihu. It is folk, not Sattriya.
- **Rouf** (रौफ) belongs to Kashmir. It is women’s rows in spring.
- **Chhau** has three homes. **Seraikella** Chhau belongs to Jharkhand. **Purulia** Chhau belongs to West Bengal. **Mayurbhanj** (मयूरभंज) Chhau belongs to Odisha and is danced without a mask. Chhau entered UNESCO in **2010**. It is not one of the Akademi eight.
- **Pulikali** belongs to Kerala. It is a tiger dance at Onam.
- **Theyyam** (तेय्यम) belongs to Kerala. It is ritual, not Kathakali.
- **Dollu Kunitha** belongs to Karnataka. It is a drum dance.

Uttar Pradesh folk

- **Raslila** belongs to Braj, around Mathura and Vrindavan. It is a Krishna folk play. It is not Manipuri classical dance.
- **Charkula** belongs to Braj. A brass lamp-tier is worn on the head.
- **Mayur nritya** belongs to Braj. It uses a peacock costume.
- **Karma** harvest dances appear in eastern Uttar Pradesh and neighbouring tribal belts. They are folk, not Akademi classical.
- **Nautanki** (नौटंकी) is Gangetic folk opera of Uttar Pradesh. It has Kanpur and Lucknow schools. It is named in the Ain-i-Akbari.
- **Chholiya** belongs to Kumaon, now in Uttarakhand and once in the UP hills. It is a sword wedding dance.
- **Kajari** is a monsoon song of Banaras and Mirzapur. It sits beside dance. It is not a classical form.

> **Logic:** Garba is UNESCO 2023 folk, **not** classical. Braj Raslila is **UP folk**.

6.11 Tribal Dances

These are Adivasi ritual dances. A few names, such as Chhau, sit on the folk–tribal edge.

- **Cheraw** belongs to **Mizoram**. It uses bamboo poles. It is not Manipur and not Nagaland.
- **Santhal** (संथाल) belongs to Jharkhand, WB, and Bihar. It is linked to Karam and Sohrai.
- **Gaur Maria** belongs to Bastar, Chhattisgarh. It uses bison-horn.
- **Dhimsa** belongs to the AP–Odisha hills. It is a circle dance.
- **Hornbill festival dances** are a Nagaland showcase. The festival is not one tribe's only dance.
- **Hojagiri** (होजगिरी) belongs to Tripura (Reang). It uses bottles or lamps on the head.
- **Wangala** (वांगाला) belongs to the Garo of Meghalaya.
- **Banjara / Lambadi** is nomadic and colourful.

UP tribal

- **Tharu** belongs to the Terai (Lakhimpur Kheri, Pilibhit, Bahraich). It is a stick or community dance.
- **Buksa / Raji** belongs to the UP–Uttarakhand border. This is a name-fact only.

> **Logic:** Cheraw belongs to **Mizoram**. Tharu belongs to **UP Terai**. Santhal is not a UP-majority fact.
